

WHAT YOUR VOLUNTEER COACH IS ACTUALLY DOING



MOST CLUB COACHES ARE NOT PAID WHAT YOU THINK. WHAT YOU ASK OF THEM MATTERS.

THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

01

What Your Volunteer Coach Is Actually Doing

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02

Parent-Coach Boundaries That Work

Coming up.

03

When You Disagree With a Coaching Decision

Coming up.

04

The Difference Between Private and Independent Training

Coming up.

05

The Season Is Long. Sustain It

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

PARENTS OFTEN HOLD VOLUNTEER
AND PART-TIME CLUB COACHES TO
PROFESSIONAL STANDARDS THEY ARE
NOT RESOURCED TO MEET.

Understanding what your coach is actually compensated for, and what they are doing out of love for the sport, changes the entire dynamic of the parent-coach relationship.

— UNDERSTAND THE LANDSCAPE BEFORE YOU JUDGE IT · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE COACHING REALITY

BEFORE YOU SEND THE 11PM TEXT,
UNDERSTAND WHAT YOUR COACH
IS ALREADY CARRYING.

- Most youth club coaches are working second jobs, volleyball is the one they love, not the one that pays
- The gap between parent expectations and coaching compensation is real and significant
- Understanding this gap is not about excusing poor coaching, it's about realistic partnership

— UNDERSTANDING THE SYSTEM IS THE FIRST STEP TO WORKING WITH IT.

THE WORKLOAD

PRACTICE HOURS

Prep, execution, and follow-up for each practice, often unpaid beyond a flat session rate.

COMMUNICATION

Parent emails, player check-ins, scheduling, logistics, the invisible workload.

TOURNAMENT DAYS

12+ hour days with full team responsibility, for a fraction of professional coaching pay.



THE PARTNERSHIP SHIFT

IN PRACTICE

Before escalating a concern, ask: 'Is this a coaching issue or an expectation mismatch?'

WATCH FOR

Whether your communication with the coach adds to or subtracts from their capacity to coach.

THE SHIFT

From consumer parent to partner parent, this changes how coaches respond to you.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE PARENT WHO UNDERSTANDS THE
SYSTEM BECOMES THE COACH'S BEST
RESOURCE. THE ONE WHO DOESN'T
BECOMES THE HARDEST PROBLEM.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, AUDIT YOUR COMMUNICATION WITH THE COACHING STAFF.

✓ Count how many messages you've sent to your coach in the last 30 days

✓ Categorize them: urgent / informational / unnecessary

✓ Commit to one communication standard: urgent only unless invited

✓ Tell the coach this week: 'I appreciate what you're doing for our team.'



PARENT-COACH BOUNDARIES THAT WORK

02

THE BEST PARENT-COACH RELATIONSHIPS HAVE CLEAR EDGES. HERE'S HOW TO SET THEM.



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THE PARENT-COACH BOUNDARY
CONVERSATION IS ALMOST NEVER
HAD, AND THEN VIOLATED ON BOTH
SIDES BY ACCIDENT.

Clear boundaries don't limit the relationship. They protect it. When parents know when and how to communicate with coaches, and coaches know what parents need, the season runs better for everyone, especially the athlete.

— CLEAR EDGES PROTECT THE RELATIONSHIP · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE BOUNDARY FRAMEWORK

THE BEST PARENT-COACH RELATIONSHIPS
HAVE ONE THING IN COMMON: EXPLICIT,
EARLY, AGREED-UPON COMMUNICATION
NORMS.

→ When: agree on appropriate times for parent-coach contact, not during practice or matches

→ How: establish the preferred channel, email, app, scheduled meeting, not text at 10pm

→ What: clarify what topics are parent-appropriate versus what belongs to the athlete

— BOUNDARIES PROTECT THE ATHLETE BY PROTECTING THE RELATIONSHIP.

COMMON VIOLATIONS

TIMING

Approaching coaches immediately after a match, when emotions are high and perspective is narrow.

CONTENT

Discussing playing time, other athletes, or coaching decisions outside of scheduled meetings.

FREQUENCY

Over-communicating in ways that signal distrust or that require significant coach time to manage.



SETTING THE STANDARD

IN PRACTICE

If your club hasn't provided communication guidelines, ask: 'What's the best way to reach you this season?'

WATCH FOR

Your own impulse to contact coaches in reactive moments, and pause before acting on it.

THE SHIFT

From reactive communication to intentional communication, this signals respect and builds trust.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

CLEAR PARENT-COACH BOUNDARIES
DON'T LIMIT SUPPORT. THEY FOCUS
IT, AND FOCUSED SUPPORT IS ALWAYS
MORE EFFECTIVE.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, ESTABLISH OR RECONFIRM COMMUNICATION NORMS WITH YOUR COACH.

✓ Email or message your coach: 'What's the best channel and timing for parent questions this season?'

✓ Share this with other parents on the team

✓ Commit to a 24-hour wait rule before any reactive communication

✓ Honor the boundaries consistently, even when it's hard



When You Disagree With a Coaching Decision

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YOU HAVE OPTIONS. MOST OF THEM ARE BETTER THAN WHAT YOU'RE CONSIDERING RIGHT NOW.



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MOST PARENT-COACH CONFLICTS
ESCALATE BECAUSE THE PARENT HAD NO
PROCESS FOR DISAGREEMENT AND ACTED
ON EMOTION.

Disagreeing with a coaching decision is normal. Handling it well is a skill. The process matters as much as the content, and the model you set for your athlete in how you handle disagreement will outlast the decision itself.

THE DISAGREEMENT PROCESS

WHEN YOU DISAGREE WITH A COACHING DECISION, THE PROCESS YOU USE IS AS IMPORTANT AS THE OUTCOME YOU WANT.

→ Wait 24 hours before any contact: emotion-driven conversations create unnecessary escalation

→ Request a meeting, not a text thread: 'Can we schedule 15 minutes to talk?'

→ Frame as a question, not a challenge: 'Can you help me understand the decision?'

— HOW YOU DISAGREE MODELS HOW YOUR ATHLETE WILL DISAGREE FOR THE REST OF HER LIFE.

THE ESCALATION PATTERN

REACT

Immediate text, emotional tone, playing time as the center of the concern, usually backfires.

APPROACH

'Can we schedule 15 minutes to talk? I want to understand something.' Always more effective.

THE MODEL

Your athlete is watching how you handle disagreement with authority. This is the lesson.



THE DISAGREEMENT SCRIPT

IN PRACTICE

Before contacting the coach: wait, frame, and approach, in that order, every time.

WATCH FOR

Whether your approach makes the coach more or less likely to hear your concern.

THE SHIFT

From making the decision the issue to making the understanding the goal.

02

07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

YOU MAY NOT CHANGE THE
COACHING DECISION. BUT YOU WILL
ALWAYS MODEL HOW DISAGREEMENT
GETS HANDLED. MAKE IT WORTH
MODELING.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, PRACTICE THE DISAGREEMENT SCRIPT ON SOMETHING REAL.

- ✓ Identify one thing about this season you've wanted to raise with the coach
- ✓ Apply: wait 24 hours, then frame as a question, then request a meeting
- ✓ Write out your opening line before you send it, how does it land?
- ✓ Debrief after: did the conversation go differently when you approached it this way?



THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN PRIVATE AND INDEPENDENT TRAINING



CLUB COACHES AND PRIVATE TRAINERS ARE NOT THE SAME ROLE. UNDERSTANDING BOTH HELPS YOUR ATHLETE MORE.

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PARENTS OFTEN EXPECT CLUB COACHES TO DELIVER THE SAME DEPTH OF INDIVIDUALIZED TRAINING THAT A PRIVATE TRAINER PROVIDES, AND ARE DISAPPOINTED WHEN THEY DON'T.

Club volleyball is a team development environment. Private training is individual skill development. Both are valuable. Neither replaces the other. Understanding this eliminates most of the unspoken tension in club programs.

— LAW 4 · KNOW WHAT EACH ENVIRONMENT IS BUILT TO DELIVER · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE ENVIRONMENT MAP

CLUB PROGRAM AND PRIVATE TRAINING
SERVE DIFFERENT FUNCTIONS. USE BOTH
WELL BY UNDERSTANDING WHAT EACH IS
ACTUALLY FOR.

→ Club: team systems, tactical development, competition preparation, team culture

→ Private training: individual skill refinement, position-specific focus, personalized feedback

→ Expecting club to deliver private outcomes creates resentment on both sides

— USE THE RIGHT TOOL FOR THE RIGHT DEVELOPMENT GOAL.

THE MAP

CLUB PROGRAM

System-level development. Your athlete is one of 12. The coach is building a team, not just a player.

PRIVATE TRAINER

Individual-level development. The full session is about your athlete's specific skills and gaps.

THE COMBINATION

Athletes who use both intelligently compound faster than those who rely on only one.



STRATEGIC DEVELOPMENT

IN PRACTICE

Identify what club provides and what private training could add, then invest accordingly.

WATCH FOR

Expecting club coaching to be private training, this misalignment creates frustration for everyone.

THE SHIFT

From evaluating the club coach on individual skill progress to evaluating her on team and tactical development.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

YOUR ATHLETE'S DEVELOPMENT
ACCELERATES WHEN YOU USE THE
RIGHT ENVIRONMENT FOR THE RIGHT
GOAL. KNOW THE DIFFERENCE.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, MAP YOUR ATHLETE'S CURRENT DEVELOPMENT INVESTMENTS.

- ✓ List all current training environments: club, school, private, open gym
- ✓ Categorize each as team-development or individual-development
- ✓ Identify the gap: what individual skill work is she not getting?
- ✓ Make one strategic adjustment based on what's missing



THE SEASON IS
LONG. SUSTAIN IT.

OS

PARENT ENERGY IS FINITE. THE ATHLETE WHO HAS A SUSTAINED PARENT IS BETTER OFF THAN ONE WHO HAS AN INTENSE ONE.

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HEAR THIS ONCE

PARENTS WHO BURN HOT AT THE BEGINNING OF THE SEASON OFTEN BURN OUT BY THE TIME IT MATTERS MOST, NATIONALS, PLAYOFFS, EVALUATIONS.

Sustainable parent energy is a competitive advantage. The athlete whose parent is emotionally steady in February is luckier than the athlete whose parent was most engaged in September.

— SUSTAINABLE PARENT ENERGY IS A COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE SUSTAINABILITY MODEL

THE BEST THING YOU CAN BE FOR YOUR ATHLETE ACROSS A FULL SEASON IS CONSISTENT, NOT INTENSE AT THE BEGINNING AND EXHAUSTED BY THE END.

→ Audit your current energy output: where are you spending the most emotional investment?

→ Identify the moments that will actually matter most, and conserve for them

→ Build a sustainable season rhythm that protects both you and your athlete

— STEADY BEATS INTENSE OVER THE COURSE OF A FULL SEASON.

THE BURN PATTERN

EARLY SEASON

High engagement, high emotion, high communication, often unsustainable over 9 months.

MID SEASON

Fatigue, frustration, and declining perspective, the period where reactive decisions happen.

LATE SEASON

When it matters most: championships, evaluations, transitions, is your energy available?



BUILDING SUSTAINABILITY

IN PRACTICE

Decide now what your sustainable season rhythm looks like, communication, attendance, emotional investment.

WATCH FOR

Signs of early burnout: exhaustion, resentment, or declining enjoyment of matches.

THE SHIFT

From maximum engagement at the start to strategic engagement across the full arc.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

YOUR ATHLETE NEEDS YOUR FULL
PRESENCE AT THE END OF THE SEASON
MORE THAN YOUR FULL PRESENCE IN
OCTOBER. PACE YOURSELF.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, DESIGN YOUR SUSTAINABLE SEASON RHYTHM.

- ✓ Map the season: what are the three or four moments that will actually matter most?
- ✓ Identify where you are currently over-investing energy relative to impact
- ✓ Design one sustainable habit: communication cadence, emotional check-in frequency, match attendance
- ✓ Share it with your partner or a trusted parent, accountability makes it stick